

Castro Adversus Haereses

Adversus omnes haereses, Liber I, Caput 9 (*Against All Heresies, Book I, Chapter 9*)

by Alfonso de Castro, O.F.M. (1495–1558), first published 1534; final recension Antwerp 1556

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- Transcribed from the Paris 1564 printing (Olivarius de Harsy) of the final (1556 Antwerp) recension; copy of the Biblioteca Universitaria de Sevilla.
- OCR of the original text by AI (claude-fable-5), from page images.
- Translation of the original text performed by AI (claude-fable-5). A published English translation of the whole work exists: Alfonso de Castro, “Against All Heresies,” trans. Paul M. Kimball (Dolorosa Press), against which this passage has been checked.
- Last Edit: July 3, 2026.
- Version: 1.0
- Selection pages: fol. 14r–14v (Lib. I, cap. 9, “Quis sit dicendus haereticus”)

Note on this selection: Castro is the textual anchor of the “negative” side in the later dispute over whether it is de fide that this particular man is pope. He is cited by Suárez, Tanner, Gaspar Hurtado, John of St. Thomas, De Lugo, Oviedo, Diana, Dominicus a SS. Trinitate, the Salmanticenses, Gonet, Palanco, and Puteobonelli — and he is the one authority on that side whom the tradition quotes verbatim (Gonet reproduces the “Leo or Clement” sentence nearly word for word). Two cautions arise from the text itself. First, Castro’s subject is the definition of a heretic and the censure attaching to denial — his conclusion is that the denier of a given pope’s legitimacy, refusing obedience on a claim of defective election, is a schismatic, not a heretic. Second, his supporting example is the Great Western Schism — a Church divided among three obediences — so the case of one claimant peacefully accepted by the whole Church is never posed; his reasoning presupposes that adherence to a putative pope is a fallible matter of fact, but he nowhere asserts that the whole Church’s peaceful acceptance could be wrong, nor discusses acceptance as a sign or cause of legitimacy at all. The chapter is numbered 9 in this recension; the “cap. 8” of part of the citation tradition belongs to an earlier recension.

Book I, Chapter 9 — Who is to be called a heretic (fol. 14r–14v)

But now it is time for the discourse to return to our aim. Since, therefore, it is so harsh a thing to brand anyone with the mark of heretic, the matter must be examined with anxious care, and one must (as the saying goes) bring the stone to the plumb-line before we pass censure, and pronounce nothing lightly. Many things, then, are required in order that someone may deservedly be called a heretic. First, that he should once have received the catholic faith in baptism. For he who was never dedicated to Christ will be reckoned an infidel, or a pagan, or a Jew, or a Saracen, or by whatever other name, yet he will not be called a heretic. Whence it is plain that Bernard of Luxemburg erred miserably, who, in drawing up his catalogue of heretics, there lists some who were never initiated into the catholic faith and therefore were not to be named heretics — such are Avicenna and Averroes, whom he inserted into the catalogue of heretics, though nothing could less properly be said of them than “heretics”; for it is well established that they embraced the sect of Mahomet. And if they were to be numbered among heretics because they were adversaries of the faith of Christ, why did he not also add Plotinus, Lucian, Libanius, Plutarch, Apuleius, and the other philosophers, who are utterly repugnant to the Christian faith[?]

Next, after the faith has been received, there is required an error in faith — namely, that he embrace some heresy. For which reason a schismatic is not, by reason of schism alone, properly to be reckoned a heretic, unless he fabricate some heresy on account of which he is divided from the unity of the Church. But because (as Augustine witnesses) there is no schism that does not fabricate some heresy for itself, so that it may appear to have departed from the Church with good reason, hence it is that a schismatic is commonly called a heretic: not because schism itself is heresy, but because it disposes toward heresy. For as we discussed in the first chapter, an external work is never to be called heresy unless the assent of the intellect be joined to it. Therefore schism cannot be called heresy unless an error of the intellect be added to it. Whence Jerome, on the epistle to the Galatians: “Between heresy and schism I judge there to be this difference: heresy holds a perverse dogma, while schism likewise separates from the Church.” Thus far Jerome.

But here it must be noted that the union [of the Church] is twofold. One comes about through charity, by which, as by joints, the members are knit together so as to cohere with their head, namely Christ; and by this is constituted that body which is said to be without spot. And in this way the unity of the Church consists in the unity of charity, whereby the members love one another and God. The other is the Church’s union through faith, by which all the faithful are one flock under one shepherd. For so says Hugh of St. Victor: by faith union is received; by charity, vivification. Thus far Hugh. And this is that Church which in the Gospel is sometimes compared to a net cast into the sea, gathering fish of every kind [Matt. 13]; sometimes to ten virgins, of whom five were foolish and five wise [Matt. 25].

Schism (which in Latin means a cutting or division) is opposed to the first union, the one that comes about through charity. For it very often happens that a man is called a schismatic who nevertheless believes the Church to be the mother of all, and holds the faith which the catholic Church holds, but is separated for this sole reason: that he denies that the pontiff was rightly and (as was fitting) elected, and therefore refuses to be subject to him, as to one whom he does not believe to be the true pontiff. Recent histories relate that a schism of just this kind lasted in the Church for almost forty years, during which she suffered three men at once bearing themselves as pontiffs — a schism ended in the Council of Constance under Sigismund, king of the Romans. Yet who would dare, in this

case, to fasten the name of heretic on any of those who called themselves pontiffs, or on those who obeyed them, when the council itself never charged this against any of them — except perhaps Benedict, who, with the council crying out against him, persisted in the schism?

For although we are bound to believe by faith that the true successor of Peter is the supreme Pastor of the whole Church, we are nevertheless not bound to believe by that same faith that Leo or Clement is the true successor of Peter, because we are not bound by catholic faith to believe of any one of them that he was rightly and canonically elected. Whence it comes about that a man who should refuse obedience to Clement or to Leo on this ground — namely, because he will say that he was not rightly elected — although he ought to be called a schismatic, is nevertheless not to be reckoned a heretic, since by this he runs counter to no catholic truth. For the things that pertain to the catholic faith are not those which now depend on fact, but those which depend on right. Otherwise, if such things did pertain to the catholic faith, it would necessarily have to follow that the Church would at some time be deceived in the faith — which no one of sound mind would ever admit. No one, therefore, is to be reckoned a heretic unless he take up an error in faith. Wherefore the favourers and defenders of heretics, even if they are sometimes called heretics, if in fact they defend only the persons and not the errors, are not to be reckoned heretics — though they will lie under the canonical penalties.

Thirdly, in order that someone may truly be called a heretic there is required (according to the opinion of certain men) that he not desert the whole catholic faith outright, but only some one, or some several, of its articles. For if he deserted the faith in its entirety, they say he is to be called not a heretic but an apostate.